

Face Setbacks, Learn From Them, And Return Stronger

The Journey of Malini Narayanamoorthi

MoU with MeitY—Malini Narayanamoorthi, President, Renesas Electronics India, meeting with Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union Minister for the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), and sharing the board that is being distributed to 300+ universities

We often expect a leader's story to begin with a straight-A student who always knew exactly where she was headed. Malini Narayanamoorthi's journey tells a different story.

Today, as President of Renesas Electronics India, she leads the India division of a global semiconductor organisation. But long before the boardroom, she was a young girl standing on a school stage during a singing competition. Midway through her performance, her voice cracked, and the audience laughed. For many, that would have been enough to avoid the stage forever. Not Malini. She went home, practised relentlessly, and returned the following year to win. She readily admits she was not even a particularly good singer. Looking back, that moment feels symbolic of the way much of her life would unfold: facing setbacks, learning from them, and returning stronger. From average grades and early career struggles to personal loss and leadership challenges, hers is not a textbook story of perfection, but one of resilience, self-awareness, and the courage to keep moving forward.

A childhood built on participation over perfection

Growing up in what she fondly calls 'old Bengaluru,' Malini recalls her days at Cluny Convent, where she seemed to be everywhere, on the sports field, on stage, in debates, and in competitions. "If you put me in anything, singing, acting, poetry, I would just go do it," she recalls with a laugh. Academics, however, occupied a very different place in her life. "Studies were always happening somewhere on the side." Even today, she jokes that her first instinct upon finding her old report cards was to hide them before her children could see them. But if academic excellence was not what defined her school years, participation did. She showed up, volunteered, competed, and, most importantly, learned how to respond when things did not go her way.

Sports reinforced that mindset early. Winning mattered, but so did discipline, teamwork, and the ability to recover from disappointment. Looking back, those experiences taught her something that would become a recurring theme throughout her life: success was rarely about getting everything right the first time. It was about showing up again after setbacks.

The foundations of character

At home, influence came from everyone in the family, including the extended family. Malini's mother brought kindness, sacrifice, and structure into her life: early mornings, tennis practice before dawn, routines that were followed without fuss, and a home that